

Boston Sunday Globe

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MAY 17, 2026

TRAPPED IN THE DARK WEB

A ‘tidal wave’ of child
exploitation surges online.
Authorities can’t keep up.

By Janelle Nanos and Shelley Murphy

GLOBE STAFF

Editor’s note: The following story contains discussions of online child sexual abuse material. If you or someone you know is the victim of digital abuse, the National Center for Missing & Exploited Children offers support and resources at 1-800-843-5678.

The father in Tennessee thought he knew what was going on behind his 13-year-old daughter’s bedroom door. She was playing video games on her Xbox, and her friends were messaging her on Discord, a popular chat app with a slogan that promises “all fun and games.”

Then he discovered who else was talking to her. And that’s when he called the police.

Grown men had been exploiting her online, the father told them. They’d been persuading her to send them nude pictures of herself.

When the investigators searched the girl’s devices, they saw one man had been talking to her since she was 12, and his messages had become increasingly sexual. He used an anonymous username on Discord — john90 — but was otherwise open about his identity with her: He was 33 years old and a schoolteacher.

The Tennessee investigators traced john90’s IP address and phone number to Brookline. After a special agent contacted a detective there in January 2025, they discovered the man’s number matched one given by the victim of a bike theft five years earlier. And that report led them to John Magee Gavin.

Gavin, who went by “Magee,” lived on the edge of Coolidge Corner, in a condo he shared with his wife. He went to a Crossfit gym and competed in Spartan races to raise money for veterans and the Animal Rescue League of Boston. And, for work, he taught science to teenagers at Boston’s Josiah Quincy Upper School. He’d previously been a sixth-grade teacher at the Pacific Rim Charter School in Hyde Park, a paraprofessional in Brookline Public Schools, a ski instructor, a camp counselor, and a tutor.

DARK WEB, Page A4

In Massachusetts, State Police received more than 23,000 CyberTipline reports about child exploitation in 2025, **A 77% INCREASE** in a single year.

Hail to the chief. Again and again and again.

Veneration of Trump the standard opener in D.C.

By Tal Kopan and Jim Puzzanghera

GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — The declarations over the course of a single week echoed through the White House, across the South Lawn, and even to the drained Reflecting Pool on National Mall. “Greatest president in my lifetime.”

“Maybe the best president ever.”

**THE END OF
NORMALCY**

“Love at first sight.”
“The greatest president of all the time — in any country, in any world, in any time.”

They came from people as varied as a White House official, a reality TV star, a world leader, and a mixed martial arts manager, and they flowed in a single direction — to the accolade-attuned ears of President Trump.

There was nothing remarkable about the events of the first week in May that spurred the outpouring of superlatives. It was simply another seven-day stretch of Trump’s second term.

Since returning to office, Trump hasn’t just solidified his grip on Republican politics and asserted his executive authority deep into the federal government. He has inspired, encouraged, and, at times, outright demanded to be showered with homage.

At events grand and mundane, from his deputies and average Americans alike, boosting Trump’s ego has become as casual as breathing.

ACCOLADES, Page A14

News startup has a novel business plan

Lexington firm aims to source funds for others

By Aidan Ryan

GLOBE STAFF

The Lexington Observer, like other local news startups that have sprouted in Greater Boston, has a bare-bones reporting team to cover town government, schools, and business openings: just one editor and one reporter for a population of 34,000 people.

Its public tax filings, however, suggest a much larger operation. The news organization has handled millions of dollars in donations in recent years, something many small nonprofit newsrooms could only fantasize about.

Only a small share of the Observer’s operational revenue comes from local donors and ads. The outlet instead survives largely on fees it collects by helping other news organizations across the country raise money.

While the “Local News Hub” program has helped the Observer pay for its own local reporting at a time when news outlets are in search of new revenue streams, some of its leaders are questioning whether it should continue. Running the program is a significant

LEXINGTON, Page A13

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\$6.00



A couple of swells

Sunday: Sunny and very warm.
High: 85-90. Low: 55-60.

Monday: Slightly cooler.
Complete report, **A22**.
Deaths, **A16-20**.

It is still possible to have a fun Maine getaway without spending a bundle.
SundayTravel, N27.

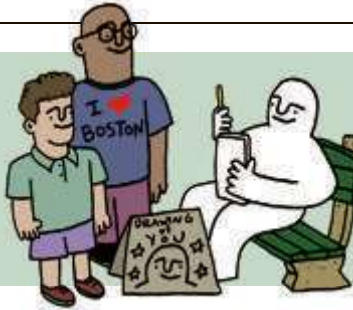
Why do patient portals leave us to fret? A

graphic look at access to medical records.
Globe Magazine.

What happens when you become an “accidental landlord?”
Address, H1.

Summer has arts of its own

From classical music to TV to dance and more, our critics have ideas for you in the **Summer Arts Guide, N1.**



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*Annual Percentage Yield (APY) is accurate as of 5/15/2026. This offer, interest rates, or APY are subject to change at any time without notice at the discretion of the Bank. Fees may reduce earnings. Minimum Deposit Requirement for opening account: \$25,000 and must be new money not already on deposit with Eastern Bank. Offer limited to one account per taxpayer identification number. Please refer to the Personal Deposit Account Agreement for details.

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